

The Ultimate Irony

It used to be the case that hacking required a great deal of skill, and that technical hurdle limited the risk of being hacked.

Today, it's no secret that WLANs are extremely easy to hack. In fact, until recently it was far easier to hack into a network than it was to protect it. Part of the problem is that WLAN technology is relatively new and highly complex. Because WLANs historically don't have the same physical protection of wired LANs, many businesses have made the conscious decision to forego the many benefits of going wireless rather than deal with the security and complexity issues involved. What has contributed to the security vulnerabilities associated with WLANs is the fact that most wireless devices—access points (APs), network interface cards (NICs), and computers—are very insecure by default.

Hackers, malicious employees, and virus writers know this and are capitalizing on it. WLAN components are very inexpensive to buy at the local discount electronics or office supply store and are very simple to install—so they are very appealing to SMB employees for home and office use. Making matters worse, the lower-cost WLAN devices tend to have fewer security controls enabled or available by default compared to the controls built into their higher-end enterprise counterparts. All of the threats covered so far concern known vulnerabilities, but what you don't know can indeed hurt you. How many of your employees are connecting to the office network via dial-up or a virtual private network (VPN)?

This can pose serious risks for any employees that have an unprotected WLAN setup at home. Anyone who is able to compromise the home WLAN can often gain access to the office network to which the employee is connected.

There are various ways that WLANs can be compromised. This includes someone walking by an office building with a laptop or wireless PDA (an act called war walking), someone sitting in the